

Animal Linguistics as an Integrative Framework for Animal Communication*

Philippe Schlenker^a, Nicolas Mathevon^{bcd}, Masato Hagiwara^f, Olivier Pietquin^f,
Emmanuel Chemla^{ef}

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Abstract: Interest in animal communication has arguably reached an all-time high, with two very visible projects—the search for the animal roots of human language and the development of methods and technologies to decode animal signals. These projects need a shared, overarching scientific framework. We argue that animal linguistics offers one, which will require close collaboration between ethologists, linguists and, increasingly, AI specialists. With the same ambition as human linguistics, animal linguistics seeks to develop explicit models of animal communication ("formal animal linguistics"), to understand the extent and limits of variation in living species ("comparative animal linguistics"), and to investigate the cognitive basis of observed properties ("animal psycholinguistics"). Through a "phylogenetic tree of animal signals", it seeks to retrace and explain the path from ancestral signals to modern ones ("evolutionary animal linguistics"). In its synchronic and diachronic components, animal linguistics offers an integrative framework for scientific and technological progress in animal communication.

Keywords: animal linguistics, animal communication, biacoustics, animal signals, evolution of communication, evolutionary animal linguistics

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1 Why animal linguistics now

Interest in animal communication has arguably reached an all-time high, both among scientists and the general public. The most visible contemporary projects aim to discover the evolutionary roots of human language ([2][102][30][32][90][91][14][97]), or to develop methods and AI-based technologies to understand animals ([68][16][31][24][66][44]). But the field lacks a shared, overarching scientific framework. We argue that animal linguistics offers one, which will require close collaboration between ethologists, linguists and, increasingly, AI specialists (see also the sister program of animal language processing [38]). Animal linguistics builds on decades of work

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^a Institut Jean-Nicod (ENS - EHESS - CNRS), Département d'Etudes Cognitives, Ecole Normale Supérieure, Paris, France; PSL Research University.

^b ENES Bioacoustics Research Laboratory, CRNL, CNRS, Inserm, University of Saint-Etienne, Saint-Étienne, France.

^c Institut Universitaire de France, Paris, France.

^d Ecole Pratique des Hautes Etudes, PSL Research University, Paris, France.

^e LSCP (ENS - EHESS - CNRS), Département d'Etudes Cognitives, Ecole Normale Supérieure, Paris, France; PSL Research University.

^f Earth Species Project.

on bioacoustics and animal signals ([55][67]), and seeks to develop formal models of animal communication that are as explicit as those of human linguistics ([76][8][90][93]). Its program has two components. In its synchronic part ([76]), it investigates current nonhuman animal communication systems as formal systems (“formal animal linguistics”), organizes their properties within a systematic typology (“comparative animal linguistics”), and investigates their cognitive basis (“animal psycholinguistics”). In its diachronic part ([79]), it reconstructs with phylogenetic methods ancestral signals that were used millions of years ago, organizes them into an evolutionary tree of animal signals, and builds models to understand their laws of evolution (“evolutionary animal linguistics”).

The synchronic part of animal linguistics is crucial to develop benchmarks to assess successes in decoding animal communication with AI technologies and large corpora ([66][57][64]), just like theoretical linguistics has helped develop benchmarks for natural language processing technologies ([51][53][39][43]). The diachronic part of animal linguistics is essential to assess the strength of purported continuities with human language, and their likely status, as deriving from convergent evolution or common descent: any continuities must be assessed in a broader typological and evolutionary background.

2 Synchronic animal linguistics offers an integrative framework for extant animal communication systems

In linguistics, the adoption of methods from logic and formal language theory in the 1950's-1960's ([22][58][59]) made it possible to (i) state theories with complete clarity, (ii) derive testable predictions from them, (iii) ask about their cognitive underpinnings, and (iv) offer a theoretically informed typology of human languages: formal linguistics is by nature comparative ([23][81][5]). The same motivations apply to animal linguistics in its formal, comparative and psycholinguistic components.

(1) The main components of animal linguistics

Component	Definition	Illustrations
Formal Animal Linguistics	It develops explicit and predictive models of the properties of a given communication system.	Definition of the signals used by a species, specification of their meanings, specification of rules of combination of signals and corresponding meanings – e.g. in Japanese tits, ABC as an alarm call, D as a recruitment call and ABC-D as a combination yielding a mobbing-related meaning.
Comparative Animal Linguistics	Using the results of Formal Animal Linguistics for diverse communication systems, it delivers a typology of their properties.	Comparison of signal functions across species— e.g. Japanese tits and chimpanzee have sequences of alarm and recruitment calls that have related functions.
Animal Psycholinguistics	It investigates (i) the cognitive abilities that underlie the properties uncovered by Formal and Comparative Animal Linguistics, and (ii) their	(i) Cognitive abilities: chimpanzees take into account the information state of their audience when producing snake alarm calls (“do not state the obvious”). This may require some ability to represent other minds. (ii) Acquisition path: vervet monkeys initially overapply eagle alarm calls, but only to birds.

	acquisition path.	
Evolutionary Animal Linguistics	It reconstructs ancestral communication systems, places them on the phylogenetic tree of species, and investigates their laws of evolution.	Phylogenetic tree of the waggle dance of bees, originating 20 million years ago and giving rise to horizontal and vertical dancing in different species. Investigation of the original dance, why it arose, and why it evolved.

To sidestep definitional issues (“are you allowed to call x a language?”), it is expedient to adopt terminology from formal language theory ([76]). Any set of strings can be called a language, and the interesting question is what its properties are. Similarly, to sidestep issues such as “what is meaning”, one can adopt the classic view, from linguistics ([41][73]), that the meaning of an expression is equated to the situations that make it true (or accurate, or appropriate, etc).

Linguistics divides communicative labor among different modules—phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics. This division follows from conceptual considerations about communicative systems in general ([76][8][77]). Applying it to animal systems doesn't imply that the specific mechanisms of human linguistics are applicable to animals, but it offers an efficient way to assess similarities and differences.

Phonological units are the cognitive atoms (= smallest relevant units) of linguistic form. In human linguistics, they were traditionally considered to be elementary sound types with dedicated time slots (phonemes), somewhat reminiscent of letters. They are now thought to be features ([40]), corresponding for instance to articulatory instructions (e.g. whether the vocal folds vibrate or not); phonemes are thus feature bundles. Some features do not have a dedicated time slot, e.g. tones that make up question intonation ([50]). The feature-based view is not tied to the vocal modality and extends to manual and facial articulators in sign language phonology ([70]).

Phonological units are usually devoid of meaning. They can be combined in rule-governed ways to create meaningful elements, morphemes—e.g. *red*, *green*, *ish*. **Morphemes** can be combined to form words (by rules of morphology)—e.g. *green+ish*→*greenish*. And words are combined by rules of **syntax** to form sentences, e.g. *This is greenish*.

To model meaning, **semantics** associates truth conditions to sentences through lexical definitions and rules of meaning combination, and **pragmatics** investigates the interaction between meaning and context (e.g. the speaker's communicative goals). In all areas, **psycholinguistics** investigates the cognitive abilities that underlie the formal properties observed ([62][73][12]).

Building on bioacoustics ([4][55]), “**animal phonology**” investigates the cognitive atoms of signal form ([98][13][30][25][7]). Concretely, this starts with the development of a minimal yet lossless transcription. It may for instance involve concatenable calls, or features, some of which may span several time slots (e.g., certain melodic slopes encode species identity or distress [54][3][78]). Things are easier when these units are meaningful (and thus morphemes) because this establishes their “cognitive relevance”, but they do not have to be. For instance, chestnut-crowned babblers have AB flight calls that coordinate group movement, and BAB prompt/provisioning calls that stimulate nestling begging. A and B are meaningless on their own, hence possibly not morpheme-like but phoneme-like ([29][13]). Vowel-like elements have been found in sperm whales, but without proof that they can be combined into meaningful elements ([7]; see also [63]). In birdsongs, notes without meaning have also been found to combine through

sophisticated rules ([6][15]). Interestingly, birdsongs usually involve patterns found in formal languages described as “regular”, a property shared with human phonology ([10][42]). This motivates a “phonological continuity hypothesis” ([33]), according to which signal sequences in animals involve rules found in human phonology, not in human syntax.

At the **morphological level** (“animal morphology”), signals may be simple or (rarely) complex. In Campbell's monkeys ([27]), the simplex calls *krak* and *hok* are used for general alerts and non-ground alerts respectively. In addition, a suffix *-oo* can yield the complex calls *krak-oo* and *hok-oo*, modifying the meaning of *krak* and *hok* in roughly the way *-ish* modifies *green* and *red* ([60][74][49][26]).

“**Animal syntax**” is concerned with combinations of signals ([101][102][47][48]). While signal sequences are very common, a key question is whether ordering restrictions result from specifically syntactic rules or from broader cognitive or physiological constraints. Campbell's monkeys have non-predation *boom* calls which always appear at the beginning of sequences. This may be seen as a rule of syntax ([99]), or possibly as reflecting production constraints, as *booms* require that the monkey fill air sacs ([76]).

On the **meaning side** (“animal semantics”), one must specify the conditions under which the smallest meaningful units are true. When they are combined, whether by rules of morphology or syntax, one must specify how the meaning of the whole is obtained. A key question is whether there are animal instances of compositionality, whereby the meaning of the whole is derived from the meaning of the parts (as in *very hot*). At the morphological level, a compositional rule was posited for Campbell's monkeys' *-oo* suffix, mentioned above. At the syntactic level, there are undoubtedly trivial instances of compositionality when calls are combined as separate utterances. Thus in titi monkeys, a series of A-calls can be followed by a series of B-calls, but it simply yields the conjunctions of their meanings, just like when Ann says *It's hot* and Bill says in roughly the same place *It's humid*: one understands that it's both hot and humid ([77]). The key question is whether there are non-trivial instances of compositionality in nonhumans (as in the case of *very hot*). One striking case was motivated for the ABC-D call of Japanese tits: ABC means “alert”, D means “help is needed”, and ABC-D serves to attract other birds to help mob a predator. Crucially, ABC-D behaves differently from separate utterances of ABC and D (e.g. as played by different loudspeakers), but its meaning is arguably derived from that of ABC and D ([92][91][77][80]). Remarkably, some researchers now argue that non-trivial compositionality in this sense is found in large corpora of bonobo and chimpanzee calls ([9][36]).

Unsurprisingly, meaning interacts with the environmental context. When titi monkeys hear an A-call (“serious non-ground threat”), they should think of raptors because they know that they are predators. A second source of enrichment involves competition among calls (“animal pragmatics”). When there is a raptor, titis could in principle produce A-calls (“serious non-ground threat”) or B-calls (“general alert”), but they always start by producing A-calls. This makes sense if they use the most informative calls available ('Informativity Principle' [76][75]). On this assumption, the B-call is only used for alerts *other* than serious non-ground ones, hence an enriched meaning. While the existence of such competition principles requires further investigation ([89]), it offers powerful new analytical tools. Beyond competition principles, meaning can be enriched by reconstructing the intentions of the signaler. This is a standard property of human language, central in multiple non-literal uses of language—humans communicate by making their intentions overt ([37]), but this is thought to be beyond animals' abilities ([83]).

These levels are summarized in Table (2), with their key properties, usually sharply distinct from human counterparts, and salient hypotheses. In all areas, animal psycholinguistics investigates the cognitive abilities that underlie the properties uncovered by formal animal linguistics and their acquisition path. For instance, chimpanzees tend to produce snake alarm calls for interlocutors that have not seen the threat, following a principle ('Do not state the obvious') that might require some representation of other minds ([28][85][95]), and vervet monkeys initially overapply eagle alarm calls, but only to birds ([84][86]).

(2) Levels of organization of animal linguistics, compared with human linguistics

Domain of communication	Example	Properties and hypotheses in animals	Properties and hypotheses in humans
Phonology <i>investigates the smallest (cognitively relevant) units</i>	-Animal calls: AB vs. BAB calls in chestnut crown babblers [29] -'Phonology' without associated meanings: birdsongs [10]	Very limited Birdsong hypothesis: birdsongs are subregular languages [10]	Subregular languages [42]
Morphology <i>investigates the smallest meaningful units</i>	-oo suffix in Campbell's monkeys [60]	Very limited: few complex calls to date	Regular language [45]
Syntax <i>investigates the rules of combination of meaningful units</i>	-Trivial combinations: sequences of A and then B calls in titi monkeys [75] -Non-trivial combinations: ABC-D sequences in Japanese tits [91]	Very limited: few cases of non-trivial syntactic combinations Fitch's 'phonological syntax' hypothesis: Animal signals can be combined using the same rule types as in human phonology, not human syntax. [33] Rizzi's 1-merge hypothesis: Animals can sometimes merge signals, but non-recursively. [65]	Beyond context-free [61] Recursive merge + movement [88]
Semantics <i>investigates the rules deriving the meaning of simple and complex elements</i>	-Elementary signals: titi monkey A, B [75]; Japanese tit ABC, D [91] -Elementary acoustic features: melodic slope, nonlinearities [4] -Non-trivial composition: ABC-D sequences in Japanese tits [91]	Very limited: few cases of non-trivial semantic composition Default hypothesis: Signals are combined as separate utterances. [71][77]	Very rich (subpart of type theory in logic) [34] [96]
Pragmatics <i>investigates the interaction between meaning and context (e.g. communicative goals)</i>	-Informativity Principle: Use the most informative signal available [76] -Economy Principle: Do not state the obvious [73]	-The Informativity Principle has been posited in several species but needs further investigation. [76] -Chimpanzees might follow the Economy Principle. [28] Scott-Phillips and Heintz's hypothesis: Unlike humans, animals do not communicate by making their intentions overt. [83]	-Informativity and further principles of competition [72] -Different versions of the Economy Principle [46] -Generalized enrichment on the basis of intentions [37]

While similarities between animal and human languages are controversial, similarities *across* animal languages are striking, hence a comparative component, which seeks to determine the extent and limits of variability in animal communication systems. Cross-species similarities may be explained by common descent, by convergent evolution, or by coevolution for species that interacted over evolutionary periods. All three reasons are evolutionary in nature, and thus comparative animal linguistics leads into evolutionary animal linguistics.

3 Diachronic animal linguistics offers an integrative framework for the evolution of communication systems

Evolutionary animal linguistics uses phylogenetic information and methods to place animal signals on the tree of species, and it investigates evolutionary models that can explain observed regularities.

3.1 *Evolutionary tree of animal signals*

When DNA-based methods weren't widely available to reconstruct phylogenies, vocalization similarity was often used to reconstruct them because vocalizations were thought to be typically well-preserved ([18][35][35]). Turning the problem on its head, we can use well-established phylogenies to reconstruct the evolutionary history of animal signals ([69][94]). Strikingly, ancestral signals can be reconstructed over millions of years (by contrast, the state of human language a few hundred thousand years ago is controversial [21][32]). As an example, ABC and D calls are found throughout the family of Japanese tits (the Paridae family), and even combinations of ABC-D (in that order) likely existed in their most recent common ancestor, which lived 11 million years ago around Tibet ([69]). In further striking results, multiple ape gestures have been argued to be part of an innate repertoire that is more than 16 million years old ([17]). Systematizing these results into a tree of animal signals is an exciting collective enterprise for the field (with no assumption whatsoever that we will find a single ur-signal, as communication likely arose independently multiple times).

3.2 *Principles of signal evolution*

Ancestral signal reconstruction should help inform evolutionary models of animal signals ([87]). A key idea, made precise with evolutionary game-theoretic methods ([79]), is that the very first signals should have trouble arising. Suppose a group of residents has no signal, and a mutant starts using one. This has a small cost (e.g. the mutant might become more conspicuous to predators), but no benefit, as the residents don't understand it, so the mutant's fitness should be low. While there are multiple solution strategies, a popular one is to assume that signals are understood from the start—maybe imperfectly, but enough to have an effect ([56][82][79]). This may for instance explain why many alarm calls contain nonlinearities, which are intrinsically hard to habituate to, and aversive ([11][1]).

Beyond the very first signals, one should explain the full sequence of development of signals in evolutionary times. For instance, if there are specific and general signals (like the A- vs. B-calls in tits), a key question is which came first, and why. The development of a tree of animal signals should provide crucial constraints for evolutionary models. In addition, evolutionary models could explain how the same forces can give rise to similar signal types and even combinations in unrelated species. For instance, chimpanzees have an alarm-recruitment sequence

that is surprisingly similar to the ABC-D mobbing sequence in Japanese tits ([52]). The chimpanzee sequence might initially be a candidate for a compositional sequence found in the common ancestor of humans and chimpanzees. But the point might be moot if strong evolutionary forces made such sequences appear multiple times. This is just one case among many in which apparent continuities between animals and humans must be assessed in the background of comparative and evolutionary animal linguistics, with a broad spectrum of distant species to assess convergent evolution.

Rooted in a conceptually motivated typology of modules of communication (phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics), animal linguistics promises to offer an integrative framework for animal communication systems, a reconstruction of their ancestral forms, and principles that explain their evolution. It is the necessary foundation for the quest of the animal roots of human language. And it will provide crucial analytical tools to assess any future successes in using technology to understand animals.

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